SERIES GAME PLAN · MATCHUP MODEL

Michael Wacha vs Minnesota Twins

Mar 25, 27-28, 2027 · vs MIN at Kauffman Stadium (Opening Day)

RHP · 32 starts in 2026
Built from 2026 Statcast pitch + bat-tracking data

vs LHH Change 33% 80.7 · 4-Seam 31% 93.2 · Cutter 16% 89.6 · Curve 10% 75.8 · Sinker 8% 93.7 **vs RHH** Sinker 23% 92.9 · 4-Seam 23% 93.1 · Slider 18% 85 · Cutter 14% 89.2 · Change 14% 80.6 · Curve 9% 76.2

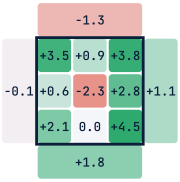
ATTACK
Changeup low and away is his best option across this lineup, worth +3.7 runs per 100 pitches over his usual mix, and it plays best against Trevor Larnach and Victor Caratini.

AVOID
His most costly habit against this group is the sinker below the zone (13% of his sinkers go there), at -5.1 runs per 100 pitches. It hurts most against Luke Keaschall and Brooks Lee.

PUT AWAY
When he's ahead in the count, the changeup low and away is the model's best finisher for 3 of 9 hitters (+3.1 runs per 100 pitches vs his usual mix when ahead).

1. Byron Buxton

RHH · 407 PA

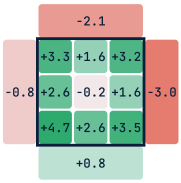


Slider map · catcher view

Attack Slider low-away **+4.5**
Cutter low-away **+3.7**
Avoid Sinker below zone **-4.5**
0-0 Slider low-away **+3.9**
Ahead Slider low-away **+3.3**
Behind Slider low-away **+6.5**
Swing length 7.9 (97p) · Attack angle 13 (87p)

2. Trevor Larnach

LHH · 435 PA

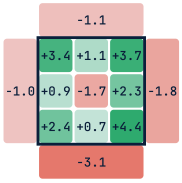


Change map · catcher view

Attack Change low-away **+4.7**
Change up-away **+3.3**
Avoid Sinker below zone **-5.1**
0-0 Change low-away **+4.2**
Ahead Change low-away **+3.6**
Behind Change low-away **+6.5**
Whiff vs OFF 38.3% (87p) · Whiff vs BRK 38.2% (85p)

3. Ryan Jeffers

RHH · 369 PA

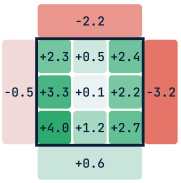


Cutter map · catcher view

Attack Cutter low-away **+4.4**
Curve low-away **+4.0**
Avoid Sinker below zone **-4.7**
0-0 Cutter low-away **+3.6**
Ahead Curve low-away **+2.9**
Behind Cutter low-away **+6.2**
Whiff vs FB 12% (10p) · Whiff vs OFF 24.4% (13p)

4. Josh Bell

LHH (S) · 631 PA

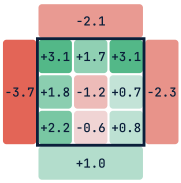


Change map · catcher view

Attack Change low-away **+4.0**
Change mid-away **+3.3**
Avoid Sinker below zone **-4.8**
0-0 Change low-away **+3.5**
Ahead Change low-away **+2.8**
Behind Change low-away **+6.0**
Swing length 7.8 (96p) · Whiff vs OFF 26.4% (22p)

5. Kody Clemens

LHH · 583 PA

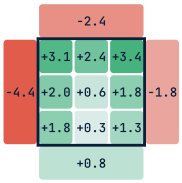


Curve map · catcher view

Attack Curve up-away **+3.1**
Change up-away **+2.9**
Avoid Sinker below zone **-5.0**
0-0 Curve up-away **+2.8**
Ahead Curve up-away **+2.3**
Behind Change up-away **+4.3**
Whiff vs OFF 25.9% (19p) · xwOBAcon 0.392 (74p)

6. Brooks Lee

LHH (S) · 629 PA

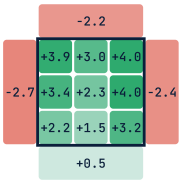


Curve map · catcher view

Attack Curve up-away **+3.1**
Change low-away **+2.9**
Avoid Sinker below zone **-5.6**
0-0 Curve up-away **+3.0**
Ahead Curve below zone **+2.1**
Behind Change low-away **+4.7**
xwOBAcon 0.313 (7p) · Zone whiff 11% (14p)

7. Luke Keaschall

RHH · 618 PA

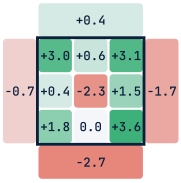


Curve map · catcher view

Attack Curve mid-away **+4.0**
Change low-in **+3.6**
Avoid Sinker below zone **-6.1**
0-0 Curve mid-away **+4.0**
Ahead Change low-in **+2.5**
Behind Change mid-in **+5.6**
Swing length 6.6 (8p) · Chase 23.5% (10p)

8. Royce Lewis

RHH · 507 PA

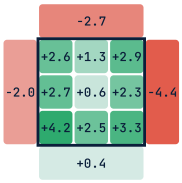


Cutter map · catcher view

Attack Cutter low-away **+3.6**
Slider low-away **+3.1**
Avoid Sinker below zone **-4.7**
0-0 Cutter low-away **+3.0**
Ahead Change below zone **+2.2**
Behind Cutter low-away **+5.2**
Swing length 8 (98p) · Whiff vs FB 25.9% (89p)

9. Victor Caratini

LHH (S) · 382 PA



Change map · catcher view

Attack Change low-away **+4.2**
Change mid-away **+2.7**
Avoid Sinker below zone **-5.4**
0-0 Change low-away **+3.7**
Ahead Change low-away **+3.0**
Behind Change low-away **+6.1**
Whiff vs FB 12.8% (12p) · Whiff vs OFF 38.3% (86p)

Values are runs per 100 pitches compared with Michael Wacha's usual 2026 mix in that count against that hitter, from the pitcher's view (+ means better for the pitcher). Recommendations only use spots where he throws that pitch at least 6% of the time; "Avoid" lists his own habits (10%+). Maps show the hitter's top attack pitch, catcher's view, with the inside edge toward the hitter. Lineup: Top 9 hitters by 2026 plate appearances for that club (Statcast pitch-level data), ordered by their median batting-order slot. Rosters will change before 2027. Model: xgboost on 712,012 pitches with shrunk hitter profiles. On the held-out late-season window, hitter × pitch × location cells r = 0.72, vs 0.60 for raw first-half splits. Devin Jenkinson · devin182.github.io/royals-pitching-rd · Independent project, not affiliated with MLB or any club.